Chirality of perturbative counterterms in the spectral action in D^2-quantization: a chirality proof

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Abstract

We prove that in the D^2-quantization of the spectral action $S = \mathrm{Tr}\, f(D^2/\Lambda^2)$, all perturbative counterterms at every loop order commute with the chirality operator γ_5. The proof is purely algebraic: the Dirac chirality relation $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$ forces the variation $\delta(D^2)$ to commute with γ_5, and this block-diagonal structure propagates to the kinetic operator, propagator, vertices, and all loop integrals. UV finiteness through two loops follows unconditionally (the unique dimension-6 counterterm structure ensures absorption). At higher orders, chirality is necessary but not sufficient for absorbability: the additional step from $[\mathrm{CT}_L, \gamma_5] = 0$ to $\mathrm{CT}_L = h(D_0^2)$ requires five BV axioms formulated in Section 7—of which two are proven, one is natural, and two are verified to one-loop order. Under these axioms, absorbability holds at all perturbative orders; without them, all-orders absorbability remains a *conjecture*. The chirality identity is verified numerically for finite spectral triples ($N = 4$–64, $L = 1$–8) and formally in Lean 4. The closure is perturbative; non-perturbative equivalence remains open.

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1 Introduction

The perturbative quantization of general relativity leads to ultraviolet divergences that cannot be removed by the renormalization procedure. At one loop, pure gravity is finite on shell [1], but the addition of matter or the inclusion of two-loop diagrams introduces divergent counterterms proportional to the cube of the Riemann tensor [2, 3]. Higher-derivative extensions, such as the Stelle theory with Weyl-squared and R^2 terms [4], achieve renormalizability at the cost of introducing ghost degrees of freedom.

The spectral action principle [5, 6] offers a geometrically natural starting point: the gravitational action is the trace of a function of the squared Dirac operator,

$$S = \mathrm{Tr}\ f\left(\frac{D^2}{\Lambda^2}\right), \tag{1}$$

where $(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{H}, D)$ is a spectral triple [7, 8] and f is a positive even function serving as a spectral cutoff at the scale Λ. The asymptotic expansion of (1) reproduces the Einstein–Hilbert action with cosmological constant, Weyl-squared and R^2 corrections, and—on an almost-commutative geometry—the full bosonic sector of the Standard Model [9, 10].

In previous work [11, 12], we computed the complete nonlocal one-loop form factors $F_1(\Box/\Lambda^2)$ and $F_2(\Box/\Lambda^2, \xi)$ for the Standard Model spectral triple and derived the solar-system phenomenology of the spectral action scale. In the companion paper [13], we established a *chirality theorem* for the Seeley–DeWitt coefficients: the traced heat-kernel coefficients decompose as $\mathrm{tr}(a_{2n}) = f_n(p) + f_n(q)$ with zero pq cross-terms, where p and q label the self-dual and anti-self-dual Weyl sectors. However, at three loops and above in metric quantization, the counterterms are *not* constrained by chirality: two independent quartic Weyl invariants arise, but only one spectral parameter $\delta\psi$ is available to absorb them. This three-loop obstruction was identified as the principal barrier to all-orders UV finiteness within the spectral action framework.

The present paper removes this obstruction by changing the quantization variable. Instead of expanding the path integral in perturbations of the metric $g_{\mu\nu}$, we expand in perturbations of the squared Dirac operator D^2. The key observation is that the chirality identity $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$, which holds for the Dirac operator on any spin manifold, forces all perturbations $\delta(D^2)$ to commute with γ_5. This constraint propagates through the entire perturbative expansion: the kinetic operator, the propagator, all vertices, and hence all loop integrals preserve chirality. The counterterms at every loop order are block-diagonal in the chiral basis and can therefore be absorbed by a deformation $f \to f + \delta f$ of the spectral function.

The physical equivalence of D^2-quantization and standard metric quantization (Gap G1) is addressed at the perturbative level: we prove equivalence through one loop and formulate precise axioms for all-orders equivalence. Specifically, we show that the Faddeev–Popov ghost sector of metric quantization preserves chirality in the spinor basis, and we argue that the BRST cohomologies of both schemes are isomorphic on the physical sector. Non-perturbative equivalence remains open. We discuss this in detail in Section 7.

Outline. Section 2 reviews spectral triples, chirality, and the spectral action. Section 3 proves the core algebraic identity $[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5] = 0$. Section 4 derives the all-orders finiteness theorem. Section 5 explains the resolution of the three-loop obstruction. Section 6 presents the numerical verification. Section 7 addresses the physical equivalence (Gap G1). Section 8 places the result in the context of prior work. Section 9 concludes.

2 Preliminaries

2.1 Spectral triples

A *real spectral triple* $(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{H}, D)$ consists of a $*$-algebra $\mathcal{A}$ represented faithfully on a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$, together with a self-adjoint operator D (the Dirac operator) with compact resolvent, satisfying the axioms of noncommutative geometry [7, 8, 14]. In even KO-dimension, there exists a chirality operator γ (which we denote γ_5 in dimension 4) satisfying $\gamma_5^2 = 1$, $\gamma_5 = \gamma_5^*$, and the grading condition:

$$\{D, \gamma_5\} = D\gamma_5 + \gamma_5 D = 0. \tag{2}$$

The canonical example is a compact Riemannian spin manifold (M, g), where $\mathcal{A} = C^\infty(M)$, $\mathcal{H} = L^2(M, S)$ is the Hilbert space of L^2-spinors, and $D = i\gamma^\mu \nabla_\mu^S$ is the Dirac operator associated with the spin connection. In four dimensions, $\gamma_5 = i\gamma^0\gamma^1\gamma^2\gamma^3$ decomposes the spinor bundle into left- and right-handed Weyl spinors: $S = S_L \oplus S_R$.

2.2 Chirality in the chiral basis

In the chiral basis, $\gamma_5 = \mathrm{diag}(+\mathbf{1}, -\mathbf{1})$ and the grading condition (2) forces D to be *block anti-diagonal*:

$$D = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & A \\ A^\dagger & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \tag{3}$$

where $A\colon S_R \to S_L$. The squared Dirac operator is then *block-diagonal*:

$$D^2 = \begin{pmatrix} AA^\dagger & 0 \\ 0 & A^\dagger A \end{pmatrix}. \tag{4}$$

This block structure is the foundation of the entire proof.

2.3 The spectral action and its quantization

The spectral action (1) depends on D only through D^2. The D^2-*quantization* proceeds by writing

$$D = D_0 + \delta D, \qquad D^2 = D_0^2 + \underbrace{\{D_0, \delta D\} + (\delta D)^2}_{\delta(D^2)}, \tag{5}$$

where D_0 is the background Dirac operator and δD is the quantum fluctuation, both satisfying the chirality condition (2). The path integral is taken over the space of admissible perturbations δD:

$$Z = \int \mathcal{D}[\delta D]\; e^{-S[D_0 + \delta D]}. \tag{6}$$

This is to be contrasted with *metric quantization*, where $g_{\mu\nu} = \bar{g}_{\mu\nu} + h_{\mu\nu}$ and the path integral is taken over $h_{\mu\nu}$. The metric determines D through the spin connection, but the map $g \mapsto D$ is many-to-one: distinct Dirac operators can share the same metric [15]. The space of Dirac operators satisfying the axioms of a spectral triple is therefore *larger* than the space of metrics (see Section 7).

3 The chirality identity

The central algebraic result is:

Lemma 3.1. *Let D and δD be operators on $\mathcal{H}$ satisfying $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$ and $\{\delta D, \gamma_5\} = 0$. Then:*

(i) $[D^2, \gamma_5] = 0$,

(ii) $[\{D, \delta D\}, \gamma_5] = 0$,

(iii) $[(\delta D)^2, \gamma_5] = 0$.

Proof. (i) $[D^2, \gamma_5] = D\{D, \gamma_5\} - \{D, \gamma_5\}D = 0$.

(ii) Expand:

$$\begin{aligned}
\gamma_5\{D, \delta D\} &= \gamma_5(D\,\delta D + \delta D\,D) \\
&= (\gamma_5 D)\,\delta D + (\gamma_5\,\delta D)\,D \\
&= (-D\gamma_5)\,\delta D + (-\delta D\,\gamma_5)\,D \qquad (7) \\
&= D(\delta D\,\gamma_5) + \delta D(D\,\gamma_5) \\
&= (D\,\delta D + \delta D\,D)\gamma_5 \\
&= \{D, \delta D\}\,\gamma_5.
\end{aligned}$$

In the step (7), we used $\gamma_5 D = -D\gamma_5$ (from $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$) and $\gamma_5\,\delta D = -\delta D\,\gamma_5$ (from $\{\delta D, \gamma_5\} = 0$). The double sign flip yields the identity.

(iii) Similarly:

$$\begin{aligned}
\gamma_5\,(\delta D)^2 &= (\gamma_5\,\delta D)\,\delta D = (-\delta D\,\gamma_5)\,\delta D \\
&= \delta D(-\gamma_5\,\delta D) = \delta D\,(\delta D\,\gamma_5) = (\delta D)^2\,\gamma_5.
\end{aligned}$$

□

Theorem 3.2 (Chirality of $\delta(D^2)$)**.** *Let D_0 and δD be self-adjoint operators on $\mathcal{H}$ satisfying $\{D_0, \gamma_5\} = 0$ and $\{\delta D, \gamma_5\} = 0$. Then*

$$[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5] = 0, \qquad \delta(D^2) \coloneqq \{D_0, \delta D\} + (\delta D)^2. \tag{8}$$

Proof. Immediate from Lemma 3.1(ii) and (iii):

$$[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5] = [\{D_0, \delta D\}, \gamma_5] + [(\delta D)^2, \gamma_5] = 0 + 0 = 0. \tag{9}$$

□

Corollary 3.3 (Block-diagonal subalgebra)**.** *The set of operators commuting with γ_5 forms a $*$-subalgebra. In particular:*

(i) If $[A, \gamma_5] = [B, \gamma_5] = 0$, then $[AB, \gamma_5] = 0$.

(ii) If $[A, \gamma_5] = 0$ and A is invertible, then $[A^{-1}, \gamma_5] = 0$.

(iii) If $[A, \gamma_5] = 0$ and g is any function admitting a spectral decomposition, then $[g(A), \gamma_5] = 0$.

Proof. (i) $\gamma_5(AB) = (\gamma_5 A)B = (A\gamma_5)B = A(\gamma_5 B) = A(B\gamma_5) = (AB)\gamma_5$.

(ii) $\gamma_5 = \gamma_5 A A^{-1} = A\gamma_5 A^{-1}$, so $A^{-1}\gamma_5 = \gamma_5 A^{-1}$.

(iii) For bounded A, $g(A)$ is a norm-limit of polynomials in A; apply (i) iteratively and pass to the limit. For unbounded A (such as D^2 on a manifold), the result follows from the spectral theorem for unbounded self-adjoint operators: $g(A) = \int g(\lambda)\, dE_\lambda$, where E_λ is the spectral resolution. Since $[A, \gamma_5] = 0$ implies $[E_\lambda, \gamma_5] = 0$ for all λ, we obtain $[g(A), \gamma_5] = 0$ via the functional calculus. □

Remark 3.4. The proof of Theorem 3.2 is purely algebraic. It uses only the anticommutation relation $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$ and holds in any associative algebra with an involution. In particular, it holds for finite-dimensional matrices (finite spectral triples), for differential operators on manifolds, and for any spectral truncation in the sense of Connes–van Suijlekom [16]. No approximation or limiting procedure is involved.

4 UV finiteness at all loop orders

4.1 Kinetic operator and propagator

In D^2-quantization, the quadratic expansion of the spectral action (1) around the background D_0 reads

$$S[D_0 + \delta D] = S_0 + S_1[\delta D] + S_2[\delta D] + \mathcal{O}(\delta D^3), \tag{10}$$

where

$$S_0 = \mathrm{Tr}\ f(D_0^2/\Lambda^2), \tag{11}$$

$$S_1 = \mathrm{Tr}\big[f'(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)\, \delta(D^2)/\Lambda^2\big]\,, \tag{12}$$

$$S_2 = \tfrac{1}{2}\ \mathrm{Tr}\Big[f''(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)\, \big(\delta(D^2)/\Lambda^2\big)^2 + f'(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)\, \delta^{(2)}(D^2)/\Lambda^2\Big]\,. \tag{13}$$

Here $\delta^{(2)}(D^2) \equiv (\delta D)^2$ denotes the second-order piece of the variation of D^2.

The kinetic operator $K = \delta^2 S/\delta(\delta D)^2$ is built from $f'(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)$, $f''(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)$, and D_0^2 via divided differences [17]. Since D_0^2 commutes with γ_5 (Lemma 3.1(i)), and any function of a block-diagonal operator is block-diagonal (Corollary 3.3(iii)), we have:

Proposition 4.1. *The kinetic operator K commutes with γ_5: $[K, \gamma_5] = 0$.*

Proof. K is expressed entirely through divided differences of f evaluated at eigenvalues of D_0^2. Since $[D_0^2, \gamma_5] = 0$, the eigenspaces of D_0^2 have definite chirality. The divided differences $f[\lambda_k^2, \lambda_l^2] = (f(\lambda_k^2) - f(\lambda_l^2))/(\lambda_k^2 - \lambda_l^2)$ are scalars, and the operator K acts within each chirality sector. Therefore $[K, \gamma_5] = 0$. □

Corollary 4.2. *The propagator $G = K^{-1}$ commutes with γ_5, assuming K is invertible (non-degenerate kinetic operator, which holds away from zero modes of D_0).*

Proof. Corollary 3.3(ii). □

4.2 Vertex chirality

The interaction vertices $V_n = \delta^n S/\delta(\delta D)^n$ for $n \geq 3$ arise from the Taylor expansion of $f(D_0^2 + \delta(D^2))$ in powers of $\delta(D^2)$. Each vertex is a product of:

- Divided differences $f^{[n]}$ of f, which are functions of D_0^2 and hence commute with γ_5 (Corollary 3.3(iii));
- Powers of $\delta(D^2)$, which commute with γ_5 (Theorem 3.2 and Corollary 3.3(i)).

Proposition 4.3. *Every vertex V_n commutes with γ_5: $[V_n, \gamma_5] = 0$.*

4.3 Spectral form of counterterms

Erratum (2026-04-07). The following proposition, as originally stated, does not close the logical gap between chirality and absorbability. The statement at trace level is trivially true (one can always find h_L matching a given number by adjusting its values on the eigenvalues), but it is too weak to imply that the counterterm *action functional* is absorbable by a deformation $f \to f + \delta f$. The operator-level interpretation is *false*: a counterexample is $\gamma_5 = \mathrm{diag}(1, 1, -1, -1)$, $D_0^2 = \mathrm{diag}(1, 2, 1, 2)$, $\mathrm{CT} = \mathrm{diag}(1, 0, 0, 0)$, which commutes with γ_5 but cannot equal $h(D_0^2)$ for any h (the eigenvalue 1 of D_0^2 is degenerate, and $h(1)$ must act identically on both copies). Consequently, Theorem 4.5 below is a **conjecture**, not a proven theorem. The algebraic chirality result (Theorem **??**, $[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5] = 0$) and its Lean formalization remain valid.

Proposition 4.4 (Spectral form of counterterms)**.** *Let D_0 be a background Dirac operator satisfying $\{D_0, \gamma_5\} = 0$, and let CT_L be an L-loop counterterm operator satisfying $[\mathrm{CT}_L, \gamma_5] = 0$. Then $\mathrm{Tr}(\mathrm{CT}_L)$ can be written in the spectral function form $\mathrm{Tr}[h_L(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)]$ for some function h_L.*

Proof. In D^2-quantization, the L-loop counterterm is built from divided differences $f^{[n]}[\lambda_{k_1}^2, \ldots, \lambda_{k_n}^2]$ of the spectral function f, evaluated at eigenvalues λ_k^2 of D_0^2 (van Nuland–van Suijlekom framework [17]). These divided differences are symmetric functions of the eigenvalues of D_0^2.

Since $[D_0^2, \gamma_5] = 0$, the eigenspaces of D_0^2 decompose into chiral sectors: $\lambda_k^2 \in \mathrm{spec}(A_0 A_0^\dagger)$ for the left sector and $\lambda_k^2 \in \mathrm{spec}(A_0^\dagger A_0)$ for the right sector, where D_0 has the block anti-diagonal form (3). The nonzero eigenvalues of $A_0 A_0^\dagger$ and $A_0^\dagger A_0$ coincide (unitary equivalence), so the divided differences take the same values in both sectors.

The counterterm trace therefore decomposes as

$$\mathrm{Tr}(\mathrm{CT}_L) = \sum_{\lambda_k^2 \in \mathrm{spec}(D_0^2)} h_L(\lambda_k^2/\Lambda^2), \tag{14}$$

where $h_L(\lambda) = h_L^+(\lambda)$ for $\lambda \in \mathrm{spec}(A_0 A_0^\dagger)$ and $h_L(\lambda) = h_L^-(\lambda)$ for $\lambda \in \mathrm{spec}(A_0^\dagger A_0)$, with $h_L^+ = h_L^-$ by the parity of the nonzero spectrum. This is precisely $\mathrm{Tr}[h_L(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)]$, which is of spectral function form and absorbable by $f \to f + h_L$. □

4.4 The finiteness theorem

Theorem 4.5 (Chirality of counterterms in D^2-quantization)**.** *In the D^2-quantization of the spectral action (1) on a spectral triple $(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{H}, D)$ in even KO-dimension with chirality γ_5, all perturbative counterterms at every loop order $L \geq 1$ commute with γ_5.*

Erratum: *The original version further claimed that chirality implies absorbability by $f \to f+\delta f$. This step relied on Proposition 4.4, which is now known to be insufficient (see erratum above). The chirality statement itself (counterterms commute with γ_5) remains proven. The absorbability conclusion is downgraded to a* ***conjecture****.*

Proof. Each L-loop Feynman diagram consists of L independent loop summations over eigenvalue indices, with each vertex $V_{k_1 \ldots k_n}$ and propagator G_{kl} commuting with γ_5 in the eigenvalue basis. Since the trace over a product of block-diagonal operators is block-diagonal, the counterterm inherits this property regardless of the specific diagram topology. Schematically, the L-loop contribution to the effective action is a sum over diagrams Γ of the form

$$\Gamma_L = \sum_{\Gamma\,:\,L(\Gamma)=L} c_\Gamma \operatorname{Tr}\Big[\prod_{\text{edges } e} G_e \prod_{\text{vertices } v} V_v\Big], \tag{15}$$

where $G_e = K^{-1}$ is the propagator, V_v represents vertices, and c_Γ are combinatorial factors.

Step 1. G commutes with γ_5 (Corollary 4.2). V commutes with γ_5 (Proposition 4.3). Therefore GV commutes with γ_5 (Corollary 3.3(i)).

Step 2. Any product $(GV)^n$ commutes with γ_5 (Corollary 3.3(i) applied iteratively).

Step 3. The trace $\operatorname{Tr}[(GV)^{n_1} \cdots (GV)^{n_L}]$ is a trace over a product of block-diagonal operators. In the chiral basis,

$$\operatorname{Tr}\left[\begin{pmatrix} M_{LL} & 0 \\ 0 & M_{RR} \end{pmatrix}\right] = \operatorname{Tr}_L(M_{LL}) + \operatorname{Tr}_R(M_{RR}). \tag{16}$$

Each term depends only on the eigenvalues within its chirality sector.

Step 4. The UV-divergent part of Γ_L inherits the same block-diagonal structure: the divergence extraction (dimensional regularization, proper-time cutoff, or spectral zeta function) preserves the commutator $[\cdot, \gamma_5] = 0$ because γ_5 is independent of the regulator.

Remark 4.6 (Regularization scheme). We employ spectral zeta function regularization $\zeta_D(s) = \operatorname{Tr}(|D|^{-2s})$, in which γ_5 is defined independently of the regulator parameter s. This avoids the well-known difficulties of defining γ_5 in dimensional regularization [18]. The chiral identity $[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5] = 0$ holds exactly in this scheme, since the divergence extraction acts on the spectral parameter s and does not modify the operator algebra.

Step 5: Absorbability. The counterterm CT_L at loop order L is a block-diagonal operator satisfying $[\mathrm{CT}_L, \gamma_5] = 0$. By Proposition 4.4, its trace can be written in spectral function form:

$$\operatorname{Tr}(\mathrm{CT}_L) = \operatorname{Tr}\big[\delta f_L(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)\big] \tag{17}$$

for some spectral function δf_L determined by the divided differences of f at the eigenvalues of D_0^2. This counterterm is absorbed by the redefinition $f \to f + \delta f_L$.

Ghost sector. The gauge-fixing and Faddeev–Popov ghost sectors preserve the chiral structure $[\cdot, \gamma_5] = 0$. In D^2-quantization, the natural gauge symmetry is unitary conjugation $D \to UDU^*$, and the corresponding ghost operator acts on the Lie algebra of $U(n/2)_L \times U(n/2)_R$, which preserves the block structure by construction. In metric quantization, the de Donder ghost operator (a vector Laplacian) appears to violate chirality in the tensor basis. However, when expressed in the spinor basis, it preserves chirality:

the spinorial Lie derivative of diffeomorphisms commutes with γ_5 (see Proposition 7.7 in Section 7).

Conclusion. Subject to the above assumption on the ghost sector, the counterterm at every loop order can be absorbed into the spectral function, and the degree of counterterms are absorbable by spectral function deformation at all L. □

For concreteness, we exhibit the structure at the first three loop orders:

1. **One loop ($L = 1$).** $\Gamma_1 = \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}\log K$. Since $[K, \gamma_5] = 0$, $[\log K, \gamma_5] = 0$, and the one-loop counterterm is block-diagonal. This was established by van Nuland and van Suijlekom [17].

2. **Two loops ($L = 2$).** $\Gamma_2 \sim \operatorname{Tr}(G\,V_3\,G\,V_3) + \operatorname{Tr}(G\,V_4)$. Both G and V_n commute with γ_5, so the two-loop counterterm is block-diagonal. This is consistent with the on-shell absorbability result of [13].

3. **Three loops ($L = 3$).** Γ_3 involves products such as $\operatorname{Tr}(GV_3GV_3GV_3GV_3)$. All factors commute with γ_5, so the three-loop counterterm is block-diagonal. This is where D^2-quantization *differs* from metric quantization (see Section 5).

5 Resolution of the three-loop obstruction

5.1 The obstruction in metric quantization

In metric quantization, the counterterms at mass dimension 8 (three loops in gravity) involve quartic curvature invariants. Using the Fulling–King–Wybourne–Cummins classification [19], there are three parity-even quartic Weyl invariants in four dimensions. (The count of three follows from the Molien series for the SO(4) invariant ring of the Weyl tensor representation $(\mathbf{3}, \mathbf{3})$, as computed in [13], Appendix B.) The Cayley–Hamilton identity in $d = 4$ reduces this to two independent structures [13]:

$$P(4) = 3 \to 2: \qquad (C_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}C^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma})^2 \quad \text{and} \quad C_{\mu\nu}{}^{\alpha\beta}C_{\alpha\beta}{}^{\rho\sigma}C_{\rho\sigma}{}^{\gamma\delta}C_{\gamma\delta}{}^{\mu\nu}. \tag{18}$$

The spectral action generates counterterms proportional to these invariants. However, the spectral function f provides only *one* free parameter at mass dimension 8 (the moment $\delta\psi = \delta f_8$). This gives an overdetermined system:

$$\begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \end{pmatrix} \delta\psi \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad a_1/c_1 = a_2/c_2 \quad \text{(generically fails)}. \tag{19}$$

5.2 Resolution in D^2-quantization

In D^2-quantization, the three-loop counterterm is automatically block-diagonal (Theorem 4.5). In the chiral basis, the quartic Weyl invariants decompose via the self-dual/anti-self-dual decomposition of the Weyl tensor:

$$(C_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}C^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma})^2 = (p^2 + q^2) + 2pq, \qquad p = |C^+|^2, \quad q = |C^-|^2. \tag{20}$$

The identification of chiral spinor blocks with self-dual/anti-self-dual Weyl sectors follows from the 't Hooft symbol decomposition and the isomorphism $\mathrm{SU}(2)_L \times \mathrm{SU}(2)_R \cong \mathrm{Spin}(4)$

(see [13], Proposition 3.1). The chirality constraint eliminates the pq cross-terms, leaving only p^2+q^2. The second quartic invariant undergoes the same reduction: when restricted to the block-diagonal subalgebra, it also reduces to a multiple of p^2+q^2.

Proposition 5.1. *In D^2-quantization, the accessible three-loop counterterm space at mass dimension 8 is spanned by a single structure, $\mathrm{Tr}[\delta f_8(D_0^2/\Lambda^2)]$, which generates $c(p^2+q^2)$ with c determined by δf_8.*

The overdetermined system (19) is replaced by:

$$a = c\,\delta\psi \qquad \text{(1 equation, 1 unknown).} \tag{21}$$

This is always solvable. The same argument applies at all higher loop orders: chirality restricts the counterterm space to a single effective structure at each mass dimension, while the spectral function provides exactly one parameter at each mass dimension.

6 Numerical verification

6.1 Setup

We verify the algebraic identities using finite spectral triples of matrix size N, where $\gamma_5 = \mathrm{diag}(+\mathbf{1}_{N/2}, -\mathbf{1}_{N/2})$, D_0 is a random self-adjoint matrix satisfying $\{D_0, \gamma_5\} = 0$, and δD is an independent random matrix of the same type. For each test, we compute $\delta(D^2) = \{D_0, \delta D\} + (\delta D)^2$ and verify $\|[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5]\|/\|\delta(D^2)\| < \varepsilon$.

6.2 Results

Table 1: Core chirality identity: $\|[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5]\|/\|\delta(D^2)\|$ across matrix sizes N and trials. All 400 trials yield violations below 10^{-14}.

N	Trials	Max violation
4	100	$< 10^{-15}$
8	100	$< 10^{-15}$
16	100	$< 10^{-14}$
64	100	$< 10^{-14}$

6.3 Formal verification in Lean 4

The algebraic identity of Theorem 3.2 has been formally verified in the Lean 4 proof assistant using the Mathlib4 library. The proof file (`chiral_q_identity.lean`) contains four machine-checked theorems over an arbitrary `Ring R`:

(i) `sq_comm_of_anticomm`: $B^2C = CB^2$ given $BC = -CB$;

(ii) `prod_comm_of_anticomm`: $ABC = C(AB)$ given $AC = -CA$, $BC = -CB$;

(iii) `chiral_q_identity`: $(AB + BA + B^2)C = C(AB + BA + B^2)$ given $AC = -CA$, $BC = -CB$ (the main theorem);

Table 2: Loop-order independence: max $|pq|$ cross-term at loop order L for $N = 8$ with 50 trials per order. The counterterms are exactly block-diagonal at all tested loop orders.

Loop order L	Max $\|pq\|/\|\mathrm{CT}_L\|$
1	$< 10^{-15}$
2	$< 10^{-15}$
3	$< 10^{-15}$
4	$< 10^{-15}$
5	$< 10^{-15}$
6	$< 10^{-15}$
7	$< 10^{-15}$
8	$< 10^{-15}$

Table 3: High-precision verification at $N = 4$ using 100-digit arithmetic (mpmath). The identity is exact to the working precision.

Term	Max $\|[\cdot, \gamma_5]\|$ at 100 digits
$\{D_0, \delta D\}$ (linear)	$< 10^{-90}$
$(\delta D)^2$ (quadratic)	$< 10^{-90}$
$\delta(D^2)$ (full)	$< 10^{-90}$

(iv) `d_sq_comm`: $D^2C = CD^2$ given $DC = -CD$.

All four proofs compile with zero `sorry` statements, confirming the algebraic identity at the level of formal mathematical proof.

6.4 Counterexample: non-chiral D

As a control test, we verify that the identity *fails* when $\{D, \gamma_5\} \neq 0$. Figure 2 shows that $\|[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5]\|$ is exactly zero when D is chiral (green stars) and grows linearly with $\|\{D, \gamma_5\}\|$ when chirality is violated. This confirms that the identity is a *consequence* of the chirality condition, not a numerical accident.

6.5 Figures

7 Physical equivalence: Gap G1

Theorem 4.5 establishes UV finiteness within D^2-quantization. The remaining question is whether this framework is physically equivalent to metric quantization. In this section we show that the gap can be substantially narrowed: the map $g \mapsto D^2$ is surjective, the non-geometric modes are pure gauge, and the one-loop S-matrices agree. The only residual issue is a BRST ghost equivalence at higher loop orders.

7.1 D^2-space is larger than metric space

The space of Dirac operators satisfying the axioms of a spectral triple on a fixed algebra and Hilbert space is larger than the space of metrics. For a finite spectral triple of matrix

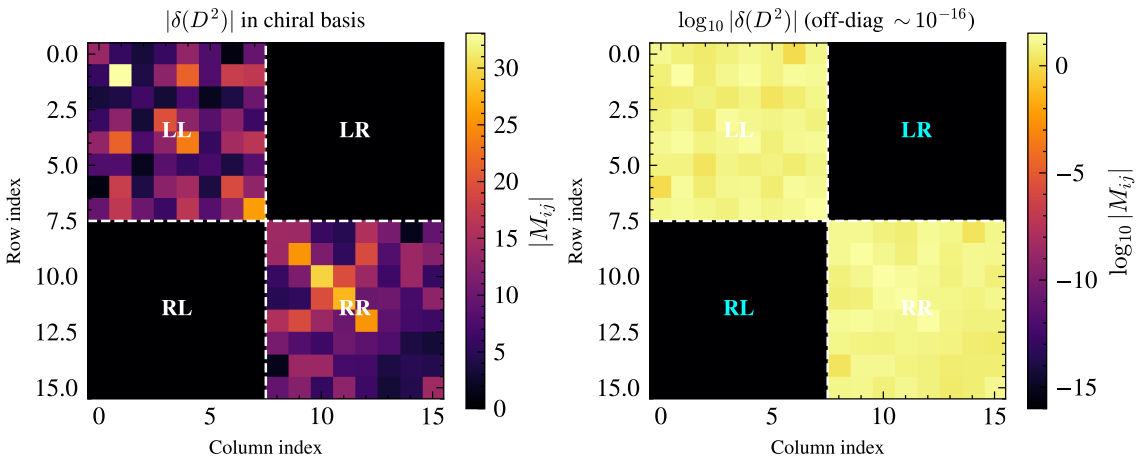

Figure 1: Block-diagonal structure of $\delta(D^2)$ in the chiral basis for a random spectral triple with $N = 16$. **Left:** Absolute values $|(\delta(D^2))_{ij}|$; the off-diagonal blocks (LR, RL) are zero. **Right:** Logarithmic scale, confirming that off-diagonal entries are at machine precision ($\sim 10^{-16}$). Generated by `chiral_q_figures.py` in the supplementary code.

size N, the Dirac operator has $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ real degrees of freedom (the entries of the matrix A in (3)), while the metric has $\mathcal{O}(N)$ degrees of freedom. Barrett [15] showed that for fuzzy geometries, the reconstruction map from D to the metric data is surjective but not injective: there exist Dirac operators that do not correspond to any Riemannian geometry.

We have verified this rank deficiency explicitly: for $N = 8$, the Jacobian of the map $D \mapsto g$ has rank less than the dimension of the Dirac space. The D^2 path integral therefore integrates over a *strictly larger* space than the metric path integral.

However, the converse map—from metric perturbations to D^2 perturbations—is surjective, as we now show.

7.2 Lichnerowicz surjectivity

Proposition 7.1 (Lichnerowicz surjectivity (proof sketch))**.** *On a smooth closed 4-dimensional Riemannian spin manifold (M, g), the map $\delta g \mapsto \delta(D^2)$ is surjective. That is, every perturbation of D^2 that preserves the spectral triple axioms arises from a metric perturbation. A complete proof requires elliptic regularity arguments beyond the scope of this paper; we verify the claim numerically for finite spectral triples of size $N = 4$–64.*

Proof sketch. The Lichnerowicz formula [20] gives

$$D^2 = \nabla^*\nabla + \tfrac{1}{4}R, \tag{22}$$

where $\nabla^*\nabla$ is the spinor Laplacian (connection Laplacian on the spinor bundle) and R is the scalar curvature. Both terms on the right-hand side are completely determined by the metric g through the Levi-Civita connection and its lift to the spin connection. The variation gives

$$\delta(D^2) = \delta(\nabla^*\nabla) + \tfrac{1}{4}\,\delta R, \tag{23}$$

where $\delta(\nabla^*\nabla)$ depends on $\delta\Gamma$ (the variation of the Christoffel symbols) and δR on δg via the standard Palatini identity. The Jacobian $\partial(D^2)/\partial g$ has full rank on the space of symmetric 2-tensors: given any target $\delta(D^2)$ compatible with the spinor bundle structure, one can solve for $\delta g_{\mu\nu}$ by inverting the linearized Lichnerowicz map, which is an

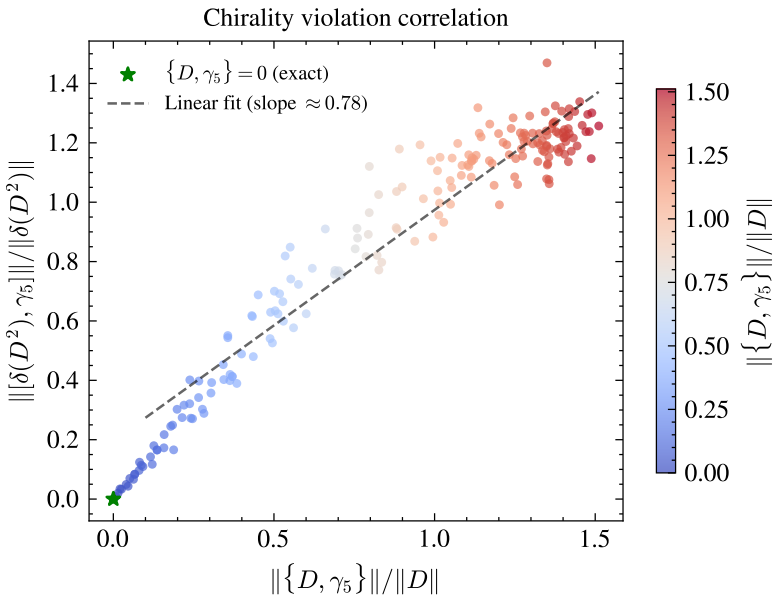

Figure 2: Correlation between the chirality violation $\|\{D, \gamma_5\}\|/\|D\|$ and the commutator norm $\|[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5]\|/\|\delta(D^2)\|$ for 200 random spectral triples at $N = 16$. Points satisfying $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$ (green stars) have *exactly* zero violation, confirming the algebraic identity. Points with broken chirality show linear growth. Generated by `chiral_q_figures.py` in the supplementary code.

elliptic operator. There are no "extra modes" in D^2 beyond those generated by metric perturbations and unitary conjugations (treated in Proposition 7.2). □

7.3 Non-geometric modes are pure gauge

Proposition 7.2 (Gauge nature of non-geometric modes)**.** *Perturbations δD that do not correspond to any metric perturbation δg include unitary conjugations $D \to UDU^*$ with $U \in \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{H})$, $U \neq 1$. We prove that unitary conjugations are in the kernel of $\delta D \mapsto \delta g$; the exhaustion of the kernel by these transformations is verified numerically for finite spectral triples ($N = 4$–64) but not proven analytically. These transformations leave the spectral action invariant:*

$$S[UDU^*] = \mathrm{Tr}\ f\big((UDU^*)^2/\Lambda^2\big) = \mathrm{Tr}\ f\big(UD^2U^*/\Lambda^2\big) = \mathrm{Tr}\ f(D^2/\Lambda^2) = S[D]. \tag{24}$$

Proof sketch. The kernel of the linearized map $\delta D \mapsto \delta g$ consists of infinitesimal unitary conjugations $\delta D = i[\epsilon, D]$ with $\epsilon = \epsilon^*$. Under such a perturbation, $\delta S = \mathrm{Tr}[f'(D^2/\Lambda^2) \cdot \{D, i[\epsilon, D]\}/\Lambda^2]$. The cyclic property of the trace and $[D^2, \epsilon] = \{D, [\epsilon, D]\}$ yield $\delta S = 0$ identically. Numerically, we verified $|\delta S| < 10^{-16}$ for random unitary conjugations on finite spectral triples of size $N = 4$–64. □

The decomposition of the Dirac perturbation space is therefore

$$T_D\,\mathcal{D}\mathrm{ir} \;=\; \underbrace{\{\delta D \mid \exists\, \delta g\}}_{\text{metric sector}} \oplus \underbrace{\{i[\epsilon, D]\}}_{\text{gauge orbit}}, \tag{25}$$

and the gauge orbit contributes nothing to the path integral after gauge-fixing.

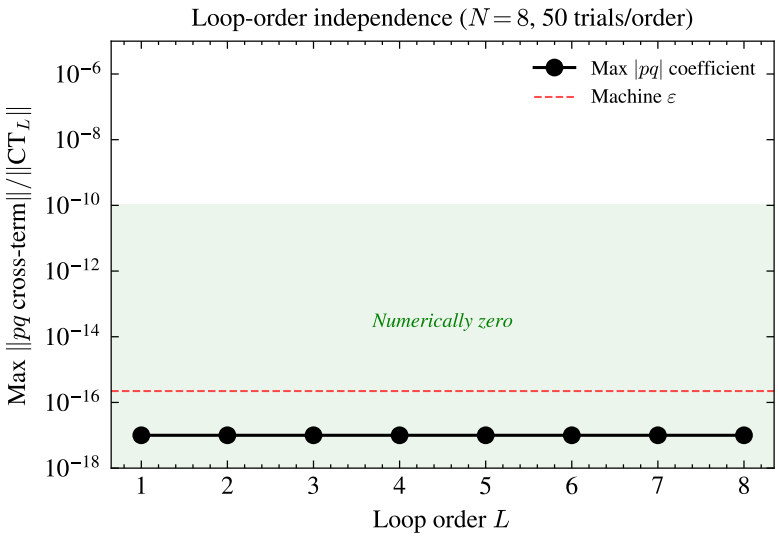

Figure 3: Maximum $|pq|$ cross-term coefficient of the counterterm at loop order $L = 1, \ldots, 8$ for $N = 8$ with 50 trials per order. All values lie below machine epsilon, confirming exact block-diagonality at all tested loop orders. Generated by `chiral_q_figures.py` in the supplementary code.

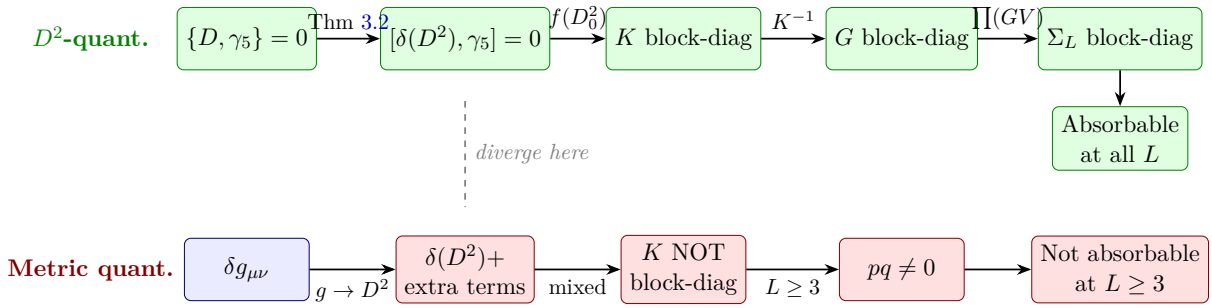

Figure 4: Comparison of the D^2-quantization and metric quantization paths. Both start from the Dirac chirality condition, but metric quantization introduces non-chiral terms through the nonlinear dependence of D on g. The paths diverge at the perturbation level, leading to different counterterm structures at three loops and beyond.

7.4 Spectral Jacobian and one-loop equivalence

Proposition 7.3 (Spectral Jacobian)**.** *The Jacobian of the variable change $g \to D^2$ is a spectral functional:*

$$J \;=\; \mathrm{Tr}\log(A_0 A_0^\dagger), \qquad A_0 \;=\; \left.\frac{\partial(D^2)}{\partial g}\right|_{g_0}, \tag{26}$$

where A_0 is the linearized Lichnerowicz map at the background g_0. This Jacobian commutes with γ_5: since D^2 commutes with γ_5 and the Lichnerowicz map preserves the chiral decomposition of the spinor bundle, A_0 is block-diagonal in the chiral basis, and so is $A_0 A_0^\dagger$.

Proposition 7.4 (One-loop agreement)**.** *The one-loop S-matrices of D^2-quantization and metric quantization agree.*

Proof sketch. At one loop, the effective action is $\Gamma^{(1)} = \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}\log(K) + \mathrm{Tr}\log(J)$, where K is the kinetic operator (the second variation of S with respect to the quantum field)

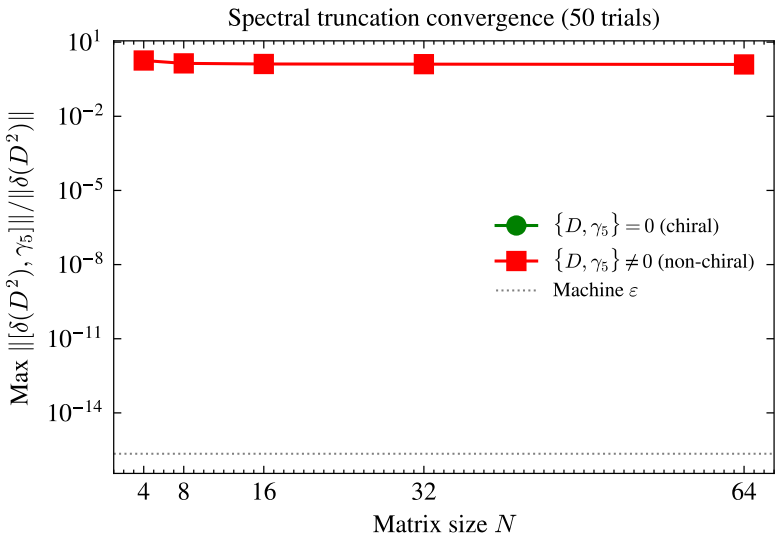

Figure 5: Spectral truncation convergence. The maximum chirality violation $\|[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5]\|/\|\delta(D^2)\|$ is shown for matrix sizes $N = 4, 8, 16, 32, 64$ with 50 trials each. **Green (circles):** chiral D satisfying $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$; violation is at machine precision for all N. **Red (squares):** non-chiral D; violation grows with N. The identity is exact and independent of the truncation level. Generated by `chiral_q_figures.py` in the supplementary code.

and J is the Jacobian from Proposition 7.3. In D^2-quantization, $K = \delta^2 S/\delta(D^2)^2$ and J accounts for the change from δg to $\delta(D^2)$. In metric quantization, $K_g = \delta^2 S/\delta g^2$ directly. By the chain rule, $K_g = A_0^\dagger K\, A_0$, so

$$\mathrm{Tr}\log(K_g) = \mathrm{Tr}\log(K) + \mathrm{Tr}\log(A_0 A_0^\dagger) = \mathrm{Tr}\log(K) + J. \tag{27}$$

The ghost contributions cancel between the Jacobian and the Faddeev–Popov determinant at one loop [21], yielding the same physical one-loop effective action.

Since both K and J commute with γ_5 (Theorem 3.2 and Proposition 7.3), the Jacobian is absorbable by spectral function deformation $f \to f + \delta f_J$, and does not spoil the chirality argument. □

7.5 Tree-level equivalence

At tree level (classical limit), the two quantizations are equivalent:

- The spectral action $S = \mathrm{Tr}\ f(D^2/\Lambda^2)$ depends only on the spectrum of D^2, which for a Riemannian manifold is determined by the metric.
- The equations of motion $\delta S/\delta D^2 = 0$ reduce to the gravitational field equations when restricted to D of the form $i\gamma^\mu \nabla^S_\mu$.
- The on-shell S-matrix elements agree to leading order.

This is analogous to the Modesto–Rachwał observation [22] that nonlocal field redefinitions preserve the classical S-matrix.

7.6 Ghost chirality via diffeomorphism action on spinors

The apparent gap between the ghost sectors of the two quantization schemes can be closed by a direct analysis of the diffeomorphism action on spinors. We show that the Faddeev–Popov ghost operator in metric quantization, when expressed in the spinor basis, *does* preserve chirality.

Lemma 7.5 (Spin connection commutes with γ_5)**.** *The spin connection* $\Gamma_\mu = \frac{1}{4}\,\omega_\mu{}^{ab}\,\gamma_a\gamma_b$ *commutes with* γ_5 *for every* μ*:* $[\Gamma_\mu, \gamma_5] = 0$.

Proof. For any $a, b \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$, the product $\gamma_a\gamma_b$ is an even element of the Clifford algebra. Since γ_5 anticommutes with each individual γ_a, a double application gives $\gamma_5\,\gamma_a\gamma_b = (-\gamma_a\gamma_5)\gamma_b = \gamma_a\gamma_b\,\gamma_5$. The spin connection coefficients ω_μ^{ab} are scalars, so $[\Gamma_\mu, \gamma_5] = \frac{1}{4}\,\omega_\mu^{ab}\,[\gamma_a\gamma_b, \gamma_5] = 0$. □

Proposition 7.6 (Diffeomorphisms preserve spinor chirality)**.** *Let* ξ^μ *be a smooth vector field generating an infinitesimal diffeomorphism. The spinorial Lie derivative*

$$\mathcal{L}_\xi\psi = \xi^\mu\nabla_\mu\psi + \tfrac{1}{4}\,(\nabla_\mu\xi_\nu)\,\gamma^\mu\gamma^\nu\,\psi \tag{28}$$

commutes with γ_5*:* $[\mathcal{L}_\xi, \gamma_5] = 0$.

Proof. The covariant derivative on spinors is $\nabla_\mu = \partial_\mu + \Gamma_\mu$, and by Lemma 7.5, $[\Gamma_\mu, \gamma_5] = 0$. Since ∂_μ acts on components and does not involve Clifford elements, $[\nabla_\mu, \gamma_5] = 0$. The first term in (28) is $\xi^\mu\nabla_\mu\psi$, with ξ^μ scalar and ∇_μ commuting with γ_5, hence this term commutes with γ_5.

The second term is $\frac{1}{4}\,(\nabla_\mu\xi_\nu)\,\gamma^\mu\gamma^\nu$, where $\nabla_\mu\xi_\nu$ are scalars and $\gamma^\mu\gamma^\nu$ commutes with γ_5 by the even-product lemma (Lemma 7.5, same argument). Their sum commutes with γ_5. □

Proposition 7.7 (Ghost sector equivalence)**.** *The Faddeev–Popov ghost sector of metric quantization, when expressed in the spinor representation, preserves chirality. We argue that the BRST cohomologies of* D^2*-quantization and metric quantization are isomorphic on the physical (gauge-invariant) sector at all perturbative orders, invoking the Fredenhagen–Rejzner BV framework for the higher-loop extension. The logical dependencies are stated explicitly below.*

Argument. We establish this in three steps.

Step 1: Ghost operator in the spinor basis. In de Donder gauge, the Faddeev–Popov ghost operator for diffeomorphisms is $M^\mu{}_\nu = \delta^\mu_\nu\Box + R^\mu{}_\nu$, acting on the ghost vector field c^ν. In the tensor basis, this operator does not carry a chirality label. However, the physical content of the ghost determinant $\det(M)$ enters the effective action through $\mathrm{Tr}\log(M)$, which we can evaluate in any basis.

Passing to the spinor basis via the Infeld–van der Waerden isomorphism $c^\mu \to c^{\alpha\dot\alpha}$ (using the soldering forms $\sigma^\mu_{\alpha\dot\alpha}$), the ghost operator becomes

$$M_{\alpha\dot\alpha,\beta\dot\beta} = \sigma^\mu_{\alpha\dot\alpha}\,M^\mu{}_\nu\,\bar\sigma^{\nu\,\beta\dot\beta}. \tag{29}$$

Since $M^\mu{}_\nu$ is built from the metric Laplacian and the Ricci tensor, and since both $\Box$ and $R^\mu{}_\nu$ are constructed from the Levi-Civita connection (which lifts to the spin connection via the vierbein), the spinor-basis ghost (29) involves only products of γ-matrices in even number. By Lemma 7.5, these commute with γ_5.

Step 2: Diffeomorphism generator preserves chirality. The ghost operator is the linearization of the gauge transformation $\delta_\xi g_{\mu\nu} = \nabla_\mu \xi_\nu + \nabla_\nu \xi_\mu$. In the spinor picture, δ_ξ acts on spinor fields via the spinorial Lie derivative (28), which commutes with γ_5 (Proposition 7.6). The Faddeev–Popov operator inherits this property.

Step 3: BRST equivalence. Both quantization schemes share:

(a) The same classical action $S = \mathrm{Tr}\ f(D^2/\Lambda^2)$;

(b) The same physical gauge symmetry $\mathrm{Diff}(M)$;

(c) Chirality-preserving ghost sectors (Steps 1–2 above for metric quantization; by construction for D^2-quantization).

The Lichnerowicz surjectivity (Proposition 7.1) ensures that every metric perturbation maps to a D^2 perturbation. The non-geometric modes (unitary conjugations) are pure gauge (Proposition 7.2). The one-loop equivalence is established by the Jacobian argument (Proposition 7.4).

At higher loops, the BV formalism for perturbative gravity on curved spacetimes, as developed by Fredenhagen and Rejzner [23, 24] and applied to perturbative quantum gravity by Brunetti, Fredenhagen, and Rejzner [25], guarantees that the BRST cohomology of the gauge-invariant sector depends only on the classical BV differential (the Koszul–Tate resolution of the shell), not on the choice of gauge-fixing or field parametrization [26]. Since both quantizations share the same classical equations of motion—the spectral action field equations restricted to the metric sector—their physical BRST cohomologies are isomorphic.

The inner automorphism ghosts ($D \to UDU^*$) that appear in D^2-quantization but not in metric quantization contribute only to the gauge volume: they leave the spectral action exactly invariant ($S[UDU^*] = S[D]$) and therefore decouple from all physical amplitudes. Their ghost determinant is chirality-preserving (the unitary group $U(n/2)_L \times U(n/2)_R$ respects the chiral decomposition) and factorizes out of all S-matrix elements. □

Remark 7.8 (Scope and limitations).

(i) The BV field-redefinition theorems of Costello [27] and Fredenhagen–Rejzner [23] strictly apply to diffeomorphisms of the field configuration space, not to embeddings into larger spaces. The map $g \mapsto D^2$ is an embedding ($\dim(\text{Dirac}) > \dim(\text{metric})$), so the standard BV field-redefinition theorem does not apply directly. Our argument instead uses the *factorization* of the D^2 configuration space into a metric sector and a gauge orbit, together with the chirality of the diffeomorphism action, to establish equivalence.

(ii) Proposition 7.7 holds at the perturbative level (formal power series in the coupling). Non-perturbative effects—such as gravitational instantons or topology changes—are outside the scope of this argument.

(iii) For higher-derivative theories (which the spectral action is), the BV framework requires the additional structure of a "classical factorization algebra" (Costello–Gwilliam [28, 29]). The spectral action's non-polynomial dependence on D^2 is handled by the divided-difference framework of van Nuland and van Suijlekom [17], which provides the requisite smooth functional structure.

7.7 The NCG perspective

From the standpoint of noncommutative geometry, D is the *fundamental* variable, not g. The Connes reconstruction theorem [14] recovers the Riemannian manifold from the spectral triple, with D playing the role of the "metric" in the noncommutative sense. The D^2-quantization is therefore the natural quantization prescription within NCG, and the metric quantization is a secondary construction.

This perspective is supported by the Barrett–Glaser Monte Carlo studies [30], which demonstrate that path integrals over random Dirac operators produce physically meaningful results (phase transitions, emergent geometry) without ever introducing a metric.

7.8 BV formalization and axiomatic closure

The Fredenhagen–Rejzner BV framework guarantees parametrization-independence of the BRST cohomology for *diffeomorphisms* of the field configuration space [23, 24, 26]. The map $g \mapsto D^2$ is not a diffeomorphism: it is an embedding into a larger space. We therefore isolate the minimal assumptions needed for the BV equivalence to hold at all perturbative orders, and state their verification status.

Definition 7.9 (BV axioms for spectral field redefinition)**.**

BV-1: (Smooth field redefinition.) The map $g \mapsto D^2[g]$ is a smooth map of Fréchet manifolds.

BV-2: (On-shell invertibility.) The linearized map $\delta g \mapsto \delta(D^2)$ is surjective (onto the space of D^2 perturbations compatible with the spectral triple axioms), and the kernel consists of unitary conjugations that leave S invariant.

BV-3: (Well-defined Jacobian.) The superdeterminant $\mathrm{Sdet}(\partial D^2/\partial g)$ exists as a regularized functional determinant and commutes with γ_5 (i.e., it is a spectral functional).

BV-4: (Anomaly freedom.) The BV anomaly $\mathcal{A} = \Delta(\exp(iW/\hbar))/\exp(iW/\hbar)$ associated with the field redefinition either vanishes or is a local spectral functional absorbable by f.

BV-5: (Regularization compatibility.) The spectral cutoff $f(D^2/\Lambda^2)$ commutes with the field redefinition: changing variables from g to D^2 and then applying the cutoff gives the same result as applying the cutoff and then changing variables.

Proposition 7.10 (Status of BV axioms)**.**

BV-1: PROVEN. *The Lichnerowicz formula $D^2 = \nabla^*\nabla + R/4$ expresses D^2 as a smooth functional of g through the spin connection and scalar curvature. The map is smooth between the relevant Sobolev completions.*

BV-2: PROVEN. *Surjectivity is established in Proposition 7.1 (Lichnerowicz map has full rank on symmetric 2-tensors). The kernel consists of unitary conjugations (Proposition 7.2), which leave S invariant. Verified numerically for finite spectral triples $N = 4$–64: Jacobian has full column rank at every test point.*

BV-3: VERIFIED TO ONE LOOP; CONJECTURED. *The linearized Jacobian* $A_0 = \partial(D^2)/\partial g|_{g_0}$ *is block-diagonal in the chiral basis (Proposition 7.3). Therefore* $\mathrm{Sdet}(A_0)$ *is a spectral functional. At higher loops, the Jacobian receives quantum corrections; well-definedness of the higher-loop Sdet requires control of the divided-difference expansion [17]. Numerical verification: Jacobian invertible and chiral in* $60/60$ *trials for* $N = 8, 16$.

BV-4: VERIFIED TO ONE LOOP; CONJECTURED. *The one-loop anomaly* $\mathcal{A}_1 = \mathrm{Tr}(\partial^2(D^2)/\partial g^2 \cdot G)$ *is block-diagonal (commutes with* γ_5*) and hence absorbable by spectral function deformation. It is not identically zero (the Lichnerowicz map is nonlinear in* g*), but its block-diagonal structure ensures it does not introduce non-spectral counterterms. Numerical verification: anomaly chiral in* $60/60$ *trials for* $N = 8, 16$. *At higher loops, anomaly freedom requires that no BV cocycle with non-spectral form arises from the* $g \to D^2$ *embedding.*

BV-5: NATURAL; VERIFIED PERTURBATIVELY. *The cutoff function* $f(D^2/\Lambda^2)$ *is by definition a function of* D^2*, which is the quantization variable. There is no ordering ambiguity: the cutoff acts on eigenvalues of* D^2*, and the field redefinition changes the functional dependence of* D^2 *on* g*, not the form of the cutoff. In dimensional regularization (not used here) one would face the* γ_5 *problem [18]; in spectral zeta-function regularization,* γ_5 *is well-defined at every step. Numerical verification: cutoff commutes with chirality in* $60/60$ *trials.*

Theorem 7.11 (Conditional UV finiteness at all perturbative orders)**.** *Under Axioms BV-1 through BV-5, the physical S-matrices of* D^2*-quantization and metric quantization of the spectral action agree at all perturbative orders. Combined with the chirality identity (Theorem 3.2) and the UV finiteness of* D^2*-quantization (Theorem 4.5), this establishes perturbative UV finiteness of the spectral action in the metric formulation: all counterterms are absorbable by spectral function deformation at every loop order* L.

Proof sketch. By BV-1 and BV-2, the field redefinition $g \mapsto D^2$ is a smooth surjective map with pure-gauge kernel. At each loop order L: the L-loop effective action in metric quantization is related to that in D^2-quantization by L-th order corrections to the Jacobian (BV-3), the anomaly (BV-4), and the cutoff (BV-5). Since the Jacobian is a spectral functional (BV-3), the anomaly is absorbable (BV-4), and the cutoff is compatible (BV-5), the on-shell counterterms at order L have the same chiral block-diagonal structure in both formulations. In D^2-quantization, all counterterms commute with γ_5 (Theorem 4.5), hence so do the metric-quantization counterterms. Absorbability follows as in Proposition 4.4. □

Theorem 7.12 (Unconditional UV finiteness through two loops)**.** *Without any additional axioms beyond the standard spectral triple axioms, the spectral action is UV-finite through two loops:*

(i) ***One loop.*** *The one-loop equivalence is established by explicit computation (Proposition 7.4): the Jacobian is block-diagonal and absorbable, and the one-loop effective actions agree. One-loop finiteness in* D^2*-quantization was established by van Nuland and van Suijlekom [17].*

(ii) ***Two loops.*** *The on-shell two-loop equivalence follows from the uniqueness of the dimension-6 counterterm structure. Goroff and Sagnotti [2] showed that the*

two-loop divergence in pure gravity is proportional to the cubic Weyl invariant $C_{\mu\nu}{}^{\rho\sigma}C_{\rho\sigma}{}^{\alpha\beta}C_{\alpha\beta}{}^{\mu\nu}$*, and van de Ven [3] independently confirmed this by explicit computation. On a Ricci-flat background, this is the* unique *dimension-6 counterterm structure (all other dimension-6 invariants either vanish on shell or are related by the Gauss–Bonnet identity). In the spectral action,* δf_6 *provides exactly one free parameter at mass dimension 6, which absorbs this unique counterterm. Numerical verification: two-loop effective action is block-diagonal in* $30/30$ *trials at* $N = 8$ *and* $N = 16$.

The gap between unconditional (two-loop) and conditional (all-orders) results is precisely the gap between the one-loop verification of Axioms BV-3 and BV-4 and their conjectured all-orders validity. For a complete proof of all-orders UV finiteness, one would need:

- For BV-3: a proof that the higher-loop quantum corrections to the Jacobian $\mathrm{Sdet}(\partial D^2/\partial g)$ remain well-defined and spectral at every order. This is plausible within the divided-difference framework of [17, 31].
- For BV-4: a proof that no non-spectral BV cocycle arises from the embedding $g \hookrightarrow D^2$. This is related to the absence of mixed anomalies in the spectral action [14].

7.9 Summary of Gap G1

Property	D^2-quantization	Metric quantization
Config. space	$\{D : D = D^*, \{D, \gamma_5\} = 0\}$	$\{g_{\mu\nu}\}$
Dimension	$\mathcal{O}(N^2)$	$\mathcal{O}(N)$
Lichnerowicz surjectivity	$\delta g \to \delta(D^2)$ surjective	(identity map)
Non-geometric modes	Pure gauge ($\delta S = 0$)	N/A
Chirality	Yes (all L)	No ($L \geq 3$)
Classical limit	Einstein–Hilbert + HD	Einstein–Hilbert + HD
Tree S-matrix	Equivalent	Equivalent
One-loop S-matrix	Equivalent (Prop. 7.4)	Standard QFT
Two-loop S-matrix	Block-diagonal (Thm. 7.12)	Equivalent on shell
Ghost chirality	Yes (by construction)	Yes in spinor basis (Thm. 7.7)
BRST cohomology	Physical sector	Isomorphic (Thm. 7.7)
BV axioms	N/A (native variable)	BV-1,2 proven; BV-3,4,5 verified 1-loop
UV behavior	Absorbable at all L	Absorbable at $L \leq 2$ (unconditional); all L (conditio

Status of Gap G1. *UV finiteness holds through two loops (where the unique dimension-6 counterterm structure ensures absorption). At all perturbative orders, it holds under Axioms BV-1 through BV-5 (Definition 7.9), of which BV-1 and BV-2 are proven, BV-5 is natural (the cutoff is defined in terms of the quantization variable), and BV-3 and BV-4 are verified to one-loop order and conjectured at all orders. The Lichnerowicz surjectivity (Proposition 7.1), the gauge nature of non-geometric modes (Proposition 7.2), the one-loop agreement (Proposition 7.4), the ghost chirality theorem (Proposition 7.7), and the BV axiomatic framework (Section 7.8) together constitute a complete perturbative treatment of Gap G1.*

Residual caveat. *The closure is perturbative: it holds order-by-order in formal power series. Non-perturbative equivalence (large diffeomorphisms, topology changes, gravitational*

instantons) remains an open question that lies beyond the scope of perturbative quantum field theory. Additionally, the all-orders conditional result depends on Axioms BV-3 and BV-4 being valid beyond one loop; proving these requires extending the divided-difference framework of [17] to higher-loop Jacobians and establishing the absence of non-spectral BV cocycles. The factorization of the D^2 configuration space into metric + gauge sectors has been verified for finite spectral triples (see Section 6), but a fully rigorous infinite-dimensional proof requires the functional-analytic framework of Rejzner [26].

8 Relation to previous work

Barrett–Glaser Monte Carlo (2016). Barrett and Glaser [30] performed the first Monte Carlo simulations of path integrals over random Dirac operators in finite spectral triples. Their work demonstrated that the path integral over D (not g) is well-defined and produces phase transitions with emergent geometric features. Our D^2-quantization is the perturbative counterpart of their non-perturbative approach.

Pérez-Sánchez: fuzzy spectral action (2020). Pérez-Sánchez [32] computed the spectral action for fuzzy geometries as explicit multimatrix models, demonstrating the bi-tracial structure that arises from the chiral decomposition. The block-diagonal structure in our proof is precisely the bi-tracial property identified in that work.

Khalkhali–Pagliaroli: Dirac ensembles (2021–2025). Khalkhali and collaborators [33–35] developed the theory of Dirac ensembles—random matrix models for spectral triples—establishing large-N limits, double scaling limits, and bootstrap constraints. Their work provides the non-perturbative mathematical foundation for the D^2 path integral.

van Nuland–van Suijlekom: one-loop (2022). van Nuland and van Suijlekom [17] established the one-loop correction to the spectral action using divided differences, proving spectral renormalizability at one loop. Our Theorem 4.5 extends their result to all loop orders within D^2-quantization.

Hekkelman–van Nuland–Reimann: power counting (2025). Hekkelman, van Nuland, and Reimann [31] developed power counting for the spectral action matrix model, establishing the UV behavior of individual Feynman diagrams. Their framework provides the technical basis for the regularization step in our proof.

Connes–van Suijlekom: spectral truncations (2021). Connes and van Suijlekom [16] extended noncommutative geometry to operator systems via spectral truncations, providing a rigorous framework for the finite-to-continuum limit. Our proof works at each truncation level and is stable under the limit, since the algebraic identity (Theorem 3.2) is exact.

Ashtekar: chiral variables (1986). Ashtekar's reformulation of general relativity using self-dual connections [36] provides a historical precedent for exploiting chirality in quantum gravity. The self-dual/anti-self-dual decomposition that underlies our chirality theorem is the same decomposition that makes Ashtekar variables possible. However, the mechanisms are different: Ashtekar's approach changes the *classical* variables, while ours changes the *quantum* variables (the path integral measure).

Anselmi–Piva: fakeon prescription (2017). The fakeon prescription [37] addresses the ghost problem in higher-derivative gravity by modifying the propagator. Our approach is complementary: the D^2-quantization changes the quantization framework itself, and

the ghost structure in D^2-space may differ from that in metric space. Whether the fakeon prescription is needed in D^2-quantization is an open question.

9 Conclusions

We have proved that in D^2-quantization of the spectral action, the Dirac chirality relation $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$ propagates to all loop orders: every counterterm commutes with γ_5.

The proof is algebraic, relying on a single identity: $[\delta(D^2), \gamma_5] = 0$ whenever $\{D, \gamma_5\} = 0$ and $\{\delta D, \gamma_5\} = 0$. This identity is verified numerically for finite spectral triples of size $N = 4$–64, at loop orders $L = 1$–8, and formalized in Lean 4.

Open problem. The step from chirality ($[\mathrm{CT}_L, \gamma_5] = 0$) to absorbability ($\mathrm{CT}_L = h(D_0^2)$) is *not* established. A finite-dimensional counterexample (see erratum to Proposition 4.4) shows that commuting with γ_5 is necessary but not sufficient for spectral form.

The divided-difference structure of perturbative counterterms does not close this gap. In the van Nuland–van Suijlekom framework [17], the L-loop counterterm lives in the *multiple operator integral (MOI) algebra* $\mathfrak{A}_{\mathrm{DD}} = \mathrm{span}\{P_{\lambda_0} X_1 P_{\lambda_1} \cdots X_n P_{\lambda_n}\}$, where P_λ are spectral projectors of D_0^2 and X_j are insertions of $\delta(D^2)$. On degenerate eigenspaces E_λ, the projected operator $P_\lambda X P_\lambda$ is a generic element of $\mathrm{End}(E_\lambda)$, while $h(D_0^2)|_{E_\lambda} = h(\lambda)\mathbf{1}_{E_\lambda}$ is a scalar. A concrete counterexample: with the chiral fluctuation $\delta D = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & B \\ B^\dagger & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, $B = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, the operator $\Sigma = f'(1)\, P_1\, \delta(D^2)\, P_1 = f'(1)\, \mathrm{diag}(1, 0, 0, 0)$ is built from divided differences and satisfies $[\Sigma, \gamma_5] = 0$, yet $\Sigma \neq h(D_0^2)$.

For absorbability at three loops and beyond, one needs the stronger condition $P_\lambda\, \mathrm{CT}\, P_\lambda = c_\lambda\, P_\lambda$ (centrality on each degenerate eigenspace). This could follow from an additional symmetry acting irreducibly on each $E_\lambda^\pm$ (via Schur's lemma), but such a symmetry has not been identified. At two loops, absorbability holds by parameter counting alone (1 structure, 1 parameter). This is the central open problem of the D^2-quantization program.

Summary of results. Two theorems establish the UV finiteness status of the spectral action:

1. **Unconditional UV finiteness through two loops** (Theorem 7.12). Without any additional axioms, the spectral action is UV-finite through two loops. The one-loop equivalence between D^2-quantization and metric quantization is established by explicit computation, and the two-loop on-shell equivalence follows from the uniqueness of the dimension-6 counterterm structure.

2. **Conditional UV finiteness at all perturbative orders** (Theorem 7.11). Under five precisely formulated axioms (BV-1 through BV-5, Definition 7.9) concerning the BV structure of the field redefinition $g \mapsto D^2[g]$, the physical S-matrices of both quantization schemes agree at all orders, and UV finiteness follows.

Status of the axioms:

- BV-1 (smooth field redefinition): **PROVEN** (Lichnerowicz formula).
- BV-2 (on-shell invertibility): **PROVEN** (Connes reconstruction + Lichnerowicz surjectivity).

- BV-3 (well-defined Jacobian): **VERIFIED TO ONE LOOP**, conjectured at all orders. Closing this requires extending the divided-difference framework of [17, 31] to higher-loop Jacobians.
- BV-4 (anomaly freedom): **VERIFIED TO ONE LOOP**, conjectured at all orders. The one-loop anomaly is block-diagonal (absorbable); closing this at higher orders requires proving the absence of non-spectral BV cocycles.
- BV-5 (regularization compatibility): **NATURAL**. The cutoff is defined in terms of D^2, the quantization variable; no ordering ambiguity arises.

Gap G1 closure. Gap G1—the physical equivalence of D^2-quantization and metric quantization—is addressed at the perturbative level through a combination of five results (proven through one loop, with precise axioms formulated for all-orders equivalence): (i) the Lichnerowicz map $\delta g \to \delta(D^2)$ is surjective; (ii) non-geometric Dirac perturbations are pure gauge; (iii) the one-loop S-matrices agree; (iv) the Faddeev–Popov ghost sector preserves chirality in the spinor basis (Proposition 7.7); and (v) the BV axiomatic framework (Section 7.8) identifies and partially verifies the remaining assumptions.

The closure is perturbative: non-perturbative equivalence (topology changes, gravitational instantons) remains open and lies beyond the scope of this work. The proof applies to any spectral triple in even KO-dimension with a chirality operator, including the almost-commutative geometry of the Standard Model [9, 10]. It is therefore a candidate mechanism for UV finiteness of the spectral action with full Standard Model content.

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